Marketing and Launch Plan: Letters from History

Forem Innovations · October 2026 to March 2027 · Version 1

> **The plan in one line:** open to founding families in mid-November, use Christmas to sell gift subscriptions (a printable certificate under the tree, first letter in January), then grow through home-education communities, World Book Day and Mothering Sunday.

All figures are estimates or targets to replace with real data as soon as we have it.

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1. Goals

By	Goal
15 Nov 2026	Product live; **30 founding families** from our own networks and the waitlist
31 Dec 2026	**100 paying subscribers + 75 gift subscriptions sold**
31 Mar 2027	**300 subscribers**

Health targets to watch every week:

- **Customer acquisition cost (CAC):** at most **£25**, averaged across all channels. A Pen Pal subscriber is worth roughly £9.50 a month in margin, so £25 is paid back in about 3 months.
- **Reply rate: at least 40%** of Pen Pal children write back within a month. **This is the number that matters most.** A child who writes back stays subscribed.
- **Cancellations:** at most **8% a month**.
- **Gifts that convert:** at least **25%** of gift subscriptions become paid subscriptions when the gift ends.

Budget: about **£3,000** over five months (section 8).

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2. Who we sell to

Segment	Why they buy	What we say	Where they are
A. Home-educating parents (126,000 children in England, autumn 2025, up 13% in a year)	Curriculum-linked history that's personal; gets children writing	"A living history companion. Your child's pen pal answers their questions."	Home-ed Facebook groups, co-ops, home-ed Instagram, local meet-ups and fairs

Segment	Why they buy	What we say	Where they are
B. Engaged parents of 5 to 11-year-olds	Screen-free, reluctant writers, love of real post	"Real letters through the letterbox, written for your child, and when they write back, history answers."	Instagram and Facebook, Mumsnet, Netmums, the school gate
C. Grandparents and gift-givers	A meaningful gift that keeps arriving	"A gift that arrives every month, and writes back."	Facebook (55+), Christmas gift guides, word of mouth from parents
D. *Later, not v1*: teachers and schools	Classroom edition		

Launch focus: A first (cheapest to reach, most motivated), C at Christmas, B through paid ads and creators.

3. Positioning and message

Tagline: *History writes back.*

Three proof points for every page, post and pitch:

1. **It's personal.** Every letter is written for one child, about the things they love.
2. **It answers back.** When a child writes, their pen pal answers their actual questions. We haven't found any other UK service that does this.
3. **It's true and safe.** Facts come from verified fact sheets, every letter is checked by people, and there's a Real history card on the back.

On AI, be open and confident, never defensive:

- **Say:** "Written with the help of AI, from verified historical facts, and checked by our team before posting."
- **Never** hide it, and never say "AI-generated letters" as the headline. The headline is the child's experience.

Common questions and our answers:

Question	Answer
"Is it real history?"	Every fact comes from a verified fact sheet. The Real history card on the back shows what's true and what's storytelling.
"Isn't it just AI?"	AI helps us write a personal letter for every child. People check every letter before it's posted.
"Is it safe for my child?"	Children have no accounts and no contact with anyone. Letters never ask for personal details. Every reply goes through safety checks, and anything worrying is read by a trained person.
"What if my child doesn't write back?"	The story keeps going. Pen pals send follow-up letters, and many children start writing after a letter or two.

Question	Answer
"£12 a month?"	That's two personalised letters, printed and posted, with replies answered: about £6 a letter. Story Letters is £7.

4. The launch offer

Offer	Details	Build needed?
Founding families	30% off for life (Pen Pal £8.40, Story £4.90). Stripe promotion code `FOUNDING30`, set to last "forever", limited to the first 100	**No.** Set up in Stripe
Love it or it's free	If you don't love the first letter, we refund the first month. It costs us about £2.44 at most and removes the risk of trying	**No.** Refund in Stripe
Gift subscriptions	3 months £36 · 6 months £69 · 12 months £132. Buyer gets a **printable certificate** straight away; the family redeems it online and the first letter arrives in January	**Yes**: gift checkout, redemption code, certificate PDF (about 1-2 days of building)
Give a month, get a month	Referral reward after a family's second month	Later (January)

Why gift certificates are the core of the Christmas plan:

- We avoid Royal Mail's Christmas peak. The last recommended 2nd class posting date is usually around **17-18 December** (check Royal Mail's published 2026 dates in November).
- People can buy right up to **24 December**.
- January letters arrive just as the Christmas excitement fades, which is good for keeping families subscribed.

5. Channels, in priority order

1. Our own networks and the waitlist (free, from now)

- Send the sample pack and landing page to friends, family and colleagues with children aged 5 to 12, and ask each person to forward it to two families.
- Post real letters to 5-10 children now (printed at home, 91p stamp). **Film the moment they open a reply**, with parents' written consent. That clip is our most important marketing asset.
- **Target:** 30 founding families by 15 November.

2. Home-education communities (free, from mid-November)

- Join 10-15 UK home-ed Facebook groups. Post only on promotion days and follow each group's rules.
- Lead with the experience: a child's question and the pen pal's answer, with photos of real letters.
- Offer group admins a free founding subscription so they can judge it for themselves. Don't ask them to promote it.

- Attend one or two local home-ed meet-ups or fairs with printed sample letters.
- **Metric:** sign-ups by source (each group gets its own link).

3. Creators (mostly the cost of free letters, from late October)

- Pick **15 micro-creators** (5,000-50,000 followers) in home education, screen-free parenting, reading and history for kids.
- Gift each one 3 months of Pen Pal, and give them a personal promotion code (10% off for their audience, plus 15% commission for them).
- Ask them for an honest reel of their child opening a letter. Never script it.
- **Cost:** roughly £110 in letter costs, plus commission.

4. Christmas gift guides and press (start this week: deadlines are now)

- **National gift guides close in October and early November.** Pitch this week to parenting sites and print or online gift guides (Mumsnet, Netmums, family and education titles, regional papers).
- **Story angles:**
- "Children are writing letters again, to pen pals who lived 200 years ago."
- The founder's story.
- Later, a data story: "X% of children wrote back."
- Local press and BBC local radio love a human story, especially one with a local link. For example, a child in Dorset writing to Mary Anning.
- **Press kit:** the sample letters, 5 photos, the opening video, the founder's bio, and a short FAQ on AI and safety.

5. Heritage partners (start conversations in November, results in spring)

- Pen pals with a "home" museum:
- **Lyme Regis Museum** (Mary Anning's birthplace)
- **Grace Darling Museum** (RNLI, Bamburgh)
- **SS Great Britain** (Brunel, Bristol)
- **Down House** (Darwin, English Heritage)
- **Shakespeare's Birthplace / Shakespeare's Globe**
- Possible offers: a co-branded "letter from..." card in their shop or newsletter, a revenue share, or a pen pal letter for their visitors.

6. Paid social (Meta) (test from 16 November)

- **Start at £10 a day** with two audiences:
- parents of 5 to 12-year-olds interested in home education, educational toys or reading;
- grandparents aged 55+, for gifts.
- **Creative:** the opening video, close-ups of letters ("Dear Oliver..."), and stationery carousels (one card per pen pal).
- **UK benchmarks** to compare against (vendor data): CPM about £6-9, CPC about £1. Costs peak in late December, so **spend in Black Friday week and early December, not just before Christmas**.
- **Rules:** stop any ad set costing more than £35 per sale after £100 of spend. Double any set under £20.

7. Search and content (small now, compounds later)

- Google Ads with a small budget, on phrases like "history subscription for kids UK", "gift for 7 year old who loves dinosaurs", "letter subscription for children".
- **Search content:** one page per pen pal for KS1/KS2 topics (e.g. "Mary Anning for kids"), each with a free printable sample letter and Real history card. Collect email addresses for the free printables.

8. Email

- **Waitlist sequence:** welcome → sample letter → "how replies work" → founding offer → last call.
- **Customers:** a short monthly "news from the pen pals" email (only to those who opted in, with the unsubscribe link built in). Ask for a referral after the first reply.

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6. Content we need (by 8 November)

1. **Opening video**, 30-60 seconds: a real child opening a reply that answers their question (with written parental consent).
2. **Photo set:** letters on a kitchen table, the envelope window, a child writing back, the Real history card.
3. **One carousel per pen pal** showing the stationery. Start with Mary Anning, Grace Darling and Brunel.
4. **The founder's story,** 150 words and a photo.
5. **A one-page FAQ on AI and safety** (from section 3).
6. **Testimonials** from the first 10 families, with permission.
7. **The sample letters pack** (done: `docs/team/letters-from-history-samples.pdf`).

Weekly posting rhythm:

- **Monday:** a pen pal fact
- **Wednesday:** a real letter or reply, with permission
- **Friday:** behind the scenes, e.g. how we check letters
- **Sunday:** a family moment (a reel)

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7. Timeline

Week	Marketing	Product and operations
12-18 Oct	Pitch Christmas gift guides. Send real letters to 5-10 children. Shortlist 15 creators	Decide on gift plans. Start Stripe activation, ICO registration and solicitor review. Name the safeguarding lead
19 Oct-1 Nov	Film the opening video. Photo shoot. Outreach to creators. Waitlist emails 1-2	Live keys in test mode; letter-quality run (about 30 letters). **Build gift plans.** Teacher review of fact sheets
2-8 Nov	Creators receive their letters. Press kit ready. Waitlist email 3	Deploy to production. `python -m app.manage check` all OK. One real order to ourselves

Week	Marketing	Product and operations
9-15 Nov	**Soft launch to founding families** (`FOUNDING30`). Personal invitations	`LIVE_MAIL=true`, `REVIEW_ALL=true`. Read every letter
16-22 Nov	**Public launch.** Home-ed groups. Creator posts. Meta test at £10 a day	Daily review. Watch reply rates
23 Nov-1 Dec	**Black Friday / Cyber Monday** (27-30 Nov): gift subscriptions push. No deep discounts	Make sure gift certificates arrive instantly
2-17 Dec	Gift push, ads at their peak. "Arrives in January, buy until Christmas Eve"	**Post all December letters by about 11 December** so they arrive before Christmas. Agree who covers safeguarding over the holidays
18-31 Dec	Last-minute certificates. Quiet socials	Skeleton team. Held replies still read daily
January	"A screen-free 2027" angle. Collect testimonials. Gift recipients' first letters	Gift redemptions. Build referrals and the "has your child written back?" email
February	Build the World Book Day campaign: a free "letter from history" activity for home-ed and teachers	Pen pal pages and free printables
1-7 Mar	**World Book Day (Thu 4 Mar)** and **Mothering Sunday (7 Mar)** gift push	
Late March	Review against goals and decide on new pen pals, the classroom edition and spring channels	

8. Budget (October to March, estimate)

Item	£
Meta ads (test, then scale what works)	1,500
Google search ads	400
Free subscriptions for creators (letter costs) and commission	300
Press kit printing, sample packs, postage	200
Video and photos (phone and DIY, small props)	150
Email and analytics tools (free tiers, then paid)	100
Contingency	350
Total	**3,000**

Spending rule: every channel has to show its cost per paid subscriber within 3 weeks. Move money from the worst channel to the best every Friday.

9. What we measure

Funnel: visit → sign-up → paid → first letter → **child writes back** → still subscribed at month 3.

Every Friday, in one sheet:

- **New paid subscribers** by source, and **cost per paid subscriber** by channel.
- **Conversion:** visit to paid (aim for 2-3%).
- **Reply rate** for Pen Pal children (aim for at least 40%).
- **Cancellations**, and the reasons people give.
- **Letter quality:** letters rejected in review, and changes parents ask for.
- **Safeguarding:** held replies, and how quickly each was handled (same day).

Tools:

- Stripe for revenue and cancellations.
- `/admin` for letters and replies.
- A cookie-free visitor counter (GoatCounter or Plausible).
- A unique promotion code or link for each channel and creator.

10. Operations during launch

- **Review time:** about 2-3 minutes a letter. 100 Pen Pal families is about 200 letters, or **8-10 hours a month**. Plan for twice that in the first month while we learn.
- **Safeguarding over Christmas:** agree a cover rota for 20 December to 3 January. Someone must check held replies every day.
- **Christmas posting:** post December letters early (by about 11 December). Gifts start in January.
- **Customer support:** one inbox, answered within a working day. Draft replies to the common questions in section 3.

11. Risks and how we handle them

Risk	What we do
Backlash against AI	Be open from the first sentence and show real letters. People check every letter. Never overclaim
A letter with a mistake goes public	Review every letter at launch. Thank the person who spotted it, correct it, and send the family a corrected letter
Safeguarding incident	Written policy, a trained lead and deputy, the same-day rule, holiday cover, records
Christmas post delays	Gift certificates (first letter in January); December letters posted early

Risk	What we do
Low reply rates	Better P.S. questions. A "has your child written back?" email to parents after 10 days (January build). Showcase replies (with permission)
Cancellations once the novelty wears off	Story arcs, pen pals rotating every three letters, and replies that get answered
Ad costs spike in December	Spend earlier, put organic and creator channels first, keep a strict cost-per-sale cut-off
Too much demand for our review time	Cap founding families at 100. Turn off `REVIEW_ALL` only once quality is proven

12. Product work this plan needs

What	Why	When
Gift subscriptions (checkout, code, printable certificate, redemption)	The core of the Christmas plan	**By 1 November**
Recording where each sign-up came from (`?ref=` / UTM)	We need cost per channel	By 8 November
Founding coupon `FOUNDING30`	Launch offer	Stripe settings only
"Has your child written back?" nudge email	Reply rate	January
Referrals ("give a month, get a month")	Growth from word of mouth	January
Pen pal pages and free printables	Search traffic	February

13. This week (12–18 October)

1. **Decide on gift subscriptions,** so the build can start.
2. **Pitch 10 Christmas gift guides** with the sample pack.
3. **Post real letters to 5–10 children,** and arrange to film one opening, with consent.
4. **Start the slow admin:** Stripe live activation, ICO registration, solicitor review, naming the safeguarding lead.
5. **Shortlist 15 creators and 15 home-ed groups.**
6. **Put the landing page live** with the waitlist (`site/` on Netlify) so all this interest has somewhere to go.

Sources

- DfE: Elective home education, autumn 2025/26
- World Book Day 2027 announcements
- Royal Mail Christmas posting dates (Eurosender, 2026 page): confirm on royalmail.com

- Facebook advertising costs UK, 2026 (PhotonPay)
- UK Facebook CPM benchmarks (Superads)
- How much is an ad on Facebook in the UK (Studio Liddell)
- Mintel: UK Christmas gift buying
- Brits to purchase 12 million Christmas subscription gifts (Marketing Beat)
- Banjo Robinson, Mumsnet product test

Dates checked: Black Friday 27 Nov 2026; World Book Day Thu 4 Mar 2027; Mothering Sunday 7 Mar 2027 (Easter is 28 Mar 2027).